and gold brocaded sari, her arms covered with bangles dripping with kaliras —as we solemnly circumambulated the sacred Guru Granth Sahib four times, before we were declared man and wife. A lavish lunch followed and then it was time for the vidai, where the bride's family bids their daughter goodbye as she formally enters her husband's home. It was a very long, emotional and tearful farewell before I tenderly put Nimmi into my trusty Fiat and we began our journey back to Chandigarh.

A grand reception was held in Chandigarh the next day before we left for our honeymoon in Srinagar. At the reception, attended by ministers, celebrated sportspeople and other distinguished guests, the chief minister, Kairon Sahib, made a speech in which he showered blessings on us and talked about the importance of genes. He said that this was a union between two illustrious sportspeople—an international sprinter and the captain of the Indian volleyball team—whose progeny would surely follow in their footsteps. He hoped that our children would be inspired by our careers and excel in the world of sports as well. At that stage, I had thought it was too early to predict the future. All that I was aware of was my new bride by my side, and that though I had won many medals, awards and prizes in my career, all these paled before Nimmi, who has remained the brightest, most treasured trophy God has given me.

Our early life together soon settled into some kind of a routine. That we both worked at the same office had its advantages, it made our daily commute much easier and gave us a common ground of interest. We also shared a deep love for sports, and Nimmi always supported and encouraged me, whether it was on the track or when I was setting up projects for the promotion of sports in Punjab. She was a brilliant administrator and I would usually ask her for advice when I was hassled by some technical detail or bureaucratic obstacle.

Our happiness multiplied when Nimmi gave birth to our first daughter in January 1964. It is one of life's most special moments to hold one's first born in one's arms, to watch her smile and gurgle, and to adapt to the joys of parenthood. We named her Aleeza, a name suggested by an English swimming coach who was a close friend of ours. Our second daughter, Mona, arrived in August 1965, followed by another daughter in December 1967. Our third daughter was named Sonia because she was *bahut soni* , so pretty. We were delighted with our daughters, and felt that our family was now complete. But fate had other plans for us, when we discovered that